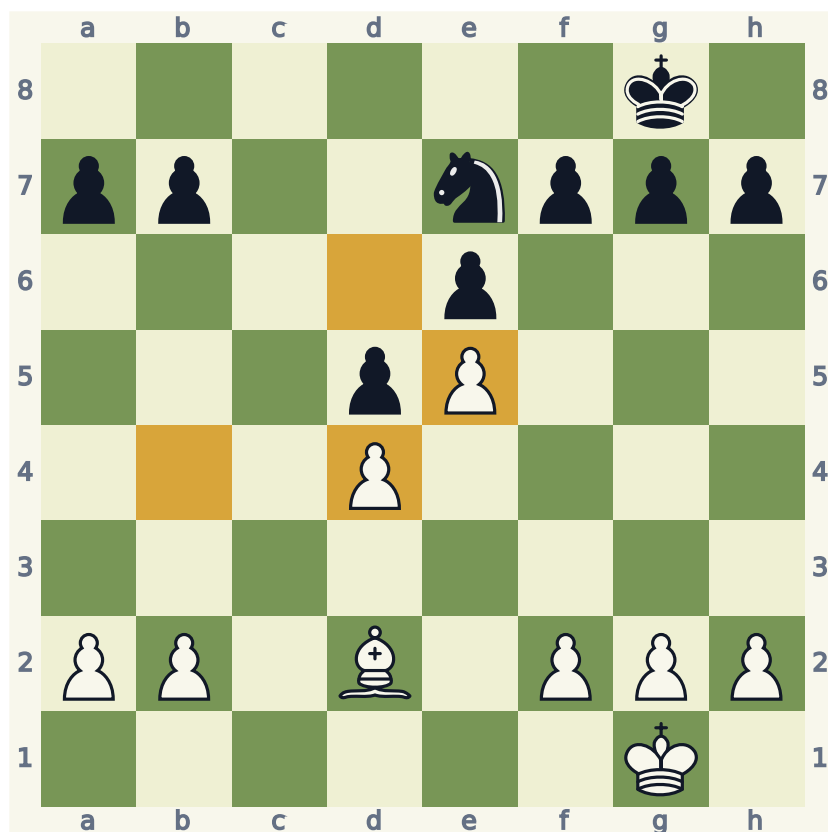


Bishops and knights

Choose the piece that fits the pawn structure.

Knights can jump over blocked pawns and use secure central posts. Bishops need open diagonals and can switch between distant targets quickly. A bishop blocked by its own central pawns is often called bad, but it may still perform essential defensive work. Judge the task, not the label.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- White's d4/e5 chain occupies dark squares.
- Bd2 is a dark-squared bishop behind that chain.
- The route d2-b4-d6 gets the bishop outside its own pawns.

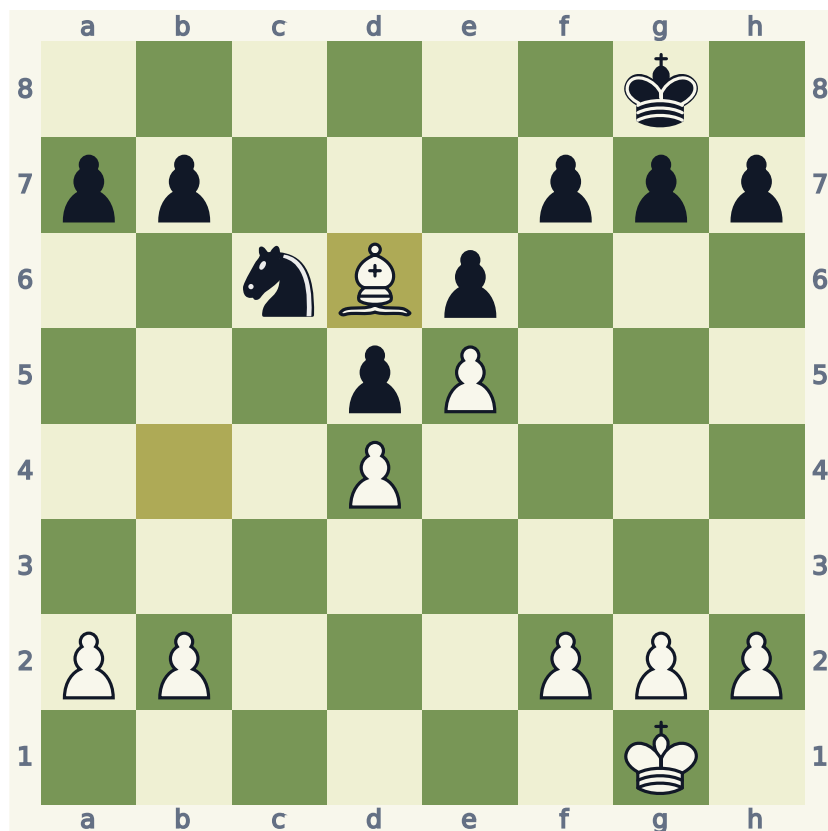
REMEMBER

- Trace actual diagonals and knight routes.
- A bad bishop can be a good defender.
- Evaluate the pawn structure after exchanges.

Follow the logic

1. Bb4 Nc6 2. Bd6

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Bb4

Use the open diagonal to escape the pawn chain. Improving the bishop can be more useful than moving another pawn onto its color.

...Nc6

Black centralizes and attacks d4. White must still watch the base of the chain while improving the bishop.

Bd6

The bishop reaches an active square protected by e5. It remains the same color bishop, but its practical activity has changed.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black can pressure d4 or seek a favorable knight route. If the bishop is exchanged, the pawn ending must be evaluated on its own merits; a good minor piece is not a substitute for king activity.

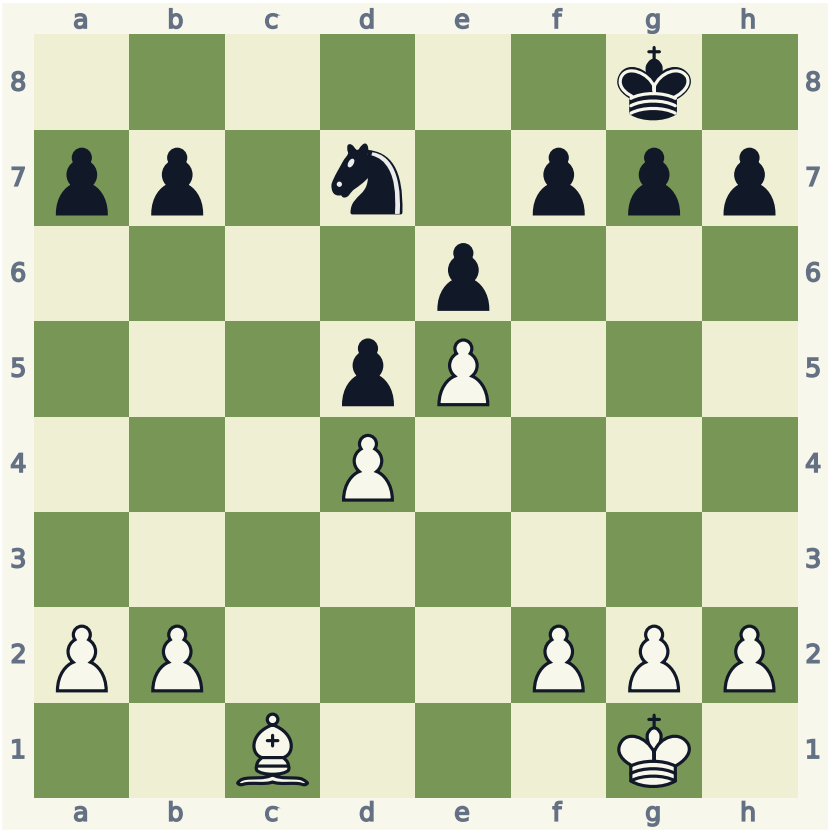
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not exchange a supposedly bad bishop if it is the only defender of critical pawns. In open positions on two wings, a bishop may be superior even when some friendly pawns sit on its color.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Is White's bishop blocked by the d4/e5 chain in the same way?
- 2. What does Bf4 achieve?
- 3. What should determine whether to keep or exchange this bishop?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If White's e5-pawn disappears, what new line does Bf4 acquire?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 6k1/pp1n1ppp/4p3/3pP3/3P4/8/PP3PPP/2B3K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Bc1 is a dark-squared bishop too, but the diagonal c1-d2-e3-f4 is clear. The central chain does not prevent development along that route. A color label cannot replace checking actual diagonals.
2. Bf4 develops outside the chain and controls g5 and h6. Its diagonal toward c7 is still blocked by White's e5-pawn. This is partial improvement, with further activity possible if the center changes.
3. Compare its real targets, the knight's possible posts and the pawn ending after an exchange. If central pawns later move or disappear, this bishop's range can change sharply.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Bf4 Nb6

Changed feature: The diagonal f4-e5-d6-c7-b8 opens, provided its other squares are clear. One pawn exchange can turn a limited bishop into a long-range attacker.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Take one bishop position and mark all squares it really reaches. Then remove one blocking pawn mentally and compare its new tasks.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 07, 09, 10. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.